



*“A broad and ample road, whose dust is gold,
And pavement stars, as stars to thee appear
Seen in the galaxy, that milky way
Which nightly as a circling zone thou seest
Powder’d with stars.”*

John Milton

THE SOLAR SYSTEM is part of a vast collection of stars, gas, and dust called the Milky Way Galaxy. Galaxies can take various forms, but the Milky Way is a spiral. The Sun and its system of planets lie halfway from the center, on the edge of one of the spiral arms. For thousands of years, humans have pondered the significance of the pale white band that stretches through the sky. This Milky Way is the light from millions of stars that lie in the disk of the galaxy. Within the Milky Way lie stars at every stage of creation, from the immense clouds of interstellar material that contain the building material of stars to the exotic stellar black holes, neutron stars, and white dwarfs that are the end points of a star’s life. Most of the Milky Way’s visible mass consists of stellar material, but about 90 percent of its total mass is made up of invisible “dark matter,” which is a mystery yet to be explained.

GLOWING PATHWAY

From Earth, the Milky Way presents a glowing pathway of stars and gas vaulting across the night sky. The billions of stars that make up the Milky Way are arranged in a great spiral disk, and from our position, halfway from its center, we view the disk end-on.

THE MILKY WAY

